

RTI Assistant — Hackathon Scope

Top 4 problems we're solving, and the researched issues we're deliberately leaving out

The 4 Core Features

1. AI Request-Sharpening (Intake)

Problem: Problem: Citizens don't know their RTI rights or how to word a request, so vague applications get vague, technically-compliant non-answers.

Solution: Solution: A short guided interview turns a plain-language complaint into a specific, statutorily-sound RTI request — naming exact documents, dates, and reference numbers instead of a generic ask.

2. Correct-Authority Routing

Problem: Problem: RTI rules, fee modes, and portals differ by state, and the official system only covers Central bodies — so citizens often file to the wrong office or don't know a state-level route exists.

Solution: Solution: Based on the issue described, the tool identifies the correct PIO / department (Central vs. specific state) and the right fee mode, including BPL exemption handling.

3. Reply-Quality Check

Problem: Problem: Responses are frequently partial, irrelevant, or delayed — and citizens have no easy way to tell if a reply is genuinely non-responsive or just needs to be accepted.

Solution: Solution: Citizen pastes in the reply they received; the tool scores it against the original request and flags whether it's actually responsive or evasive/incomplete.

4. Auto-Drafted Appeal

Problem: Problem: The first appeal is where most people give up — even when they know a reply was weak, drafting a formal appeal feels like starting over.

Solution: Solution: When a reply is flagged as weak, the tool auto-generates a first appeal that cites the specific gap between what was asked and what was given, ready to file.

Together these four map to one continuous demo arc: describe your problem → get a sharp, correctly-routed request → (time skip) → paste the reply → get told it's weak → get a ready-to-file appeal.

Researched Issues We Are NOT Solving

Real, documented pain points — deliberately left out of this build so the product stays focused on 4 things done well.

Delays, backlog & weak enforcement at Information Commissions

Structural/judicial capacity problem. We can surface it (e.g. show typical appeal wait times) but can't fix it with software.

Bureaucratic resistance & harassment of RTI filers

Serious and real, but out of scope for a software tool — acknowledged in the pitch, not built as a feature.

Poor record management & limited proactive disclosure (Section 4 non-compliance)

A government-side compliance issue, not something a citizen-facing tool fixes directly. Possible future feature, not core.

Legal & structural dilution of the RTI Act

Policy-level issue (amendments, overlapping data-protection rules reducing Information Commission independence) — not a product feature at all.

Unified cross-state case tracking / dashboard

A genuine gap (fragmented digital infrastructure), but it's a dashboard convenience layer on top of the core flow, not core problem-solving — cut for time.

Bureaucratic cost/travel barriers for offline steps

Some states still require in-person steps for parts of the process; this is an infrastructure limitation outside what an assistant layer can resolve.

Prepared as a working scope reference — sources: RTI pain-point research + product scoping discussion.